



CULTURE

## Is having a boyfriend embarrassing now?

It is now fundamentally uncool to be a boyfriend-girl

BY CHANTE JOSEPH

30 October 2025

# PATRIARCHY HIDDEN AS WITTY REMARK?



When major platforms frame relationship choices as cultural commentary, it rarely exists in a vacuum. For teenage girls — already navigating relentless scrutiny over their bodies, ambition, social lives, and online personas — these narratives don't feel abstract. They feel instructional.

What may read as a light, humorous critique of “boyfriend energy” or cultural trends can quietly reinforce a different kind of pressure: that your romantic choices are also part of your brand. That being single is progressive. That being coupled is conventional. That empowerment has an aesthetic.

Teen girls grow up under constant image calibration. This is where image policing subtly evolves. It no longer tells girls what to wear or how to look — it tells them how to position themselves.

Publications with cultural authority shape more than trends; they shape tone. When a household name treats romantic partnership as something to be analyzed through a coolness lens, it signals to young audiences that even intimacy is up for evaluation.

The issue isn't whether being single is empowering or relationships are regressive — it's the subtle pressure to frame personal choices as ideological statements. For teenage girls already navigating constant scrutiny, empowerment should expand options, not rank them.